

Bhyro Singh, the tormentor; Serang Ali, a wandering sailor and ex-pirate with a human touch; Mr Crowle, the first mate with a brutal streak... They turn the *Ibis* into a republic of stories—stories mined from the grey remoteness of history, and the deepest recesses of human mind. Ghosh creates, with ample assistance from scholarship and research, such sepia coloured set pieces: the punishment of Kalua; Zachary learning to smoke an opium pipe; the zamindar entertaining the sahibs on his private boat; Deeti's great escape... This is storytelling straight and majestic.

It is imagination accessorised by ideas—big ideas. *Sea of Poppies* is written by a novelist who is in permanent argument with the ways of the world. Ghosh is not picnicking in history; he is looking for the stray passages that are usually not worthy of a place in standard texts. He excels as the surveyor of the twilight zones in history, like the Ghazipur opium factory. The empire is kept alive by such dizzying enterprises. His anti-colonial angst has produced quite a few English caricatures though, and they remain one-dimensional as against the finely sculpted human—and humanising—figures who inhabit this novel that provide a conducted tour to anybody interested in sailing and opium. This from Burnham, the apostle of free trade and the owner of the *Ibis*: "So you would do well to bear in mind that it would be well nigh impossible to practise modern medicine or surgery without such chemicals as morphine, codeine and narcotine—and these are but a few of the blessings derived from opium." There are more, indeed. The dull, muddy-coloured substance, in the cruellest way, changes the life of Deeti. She will have her payback time. She stares into the ocean from the main deck of the *Ibis*, as the liberator and the liberated.

The real blessing, though, is this richly textured, minutely researched, novel that chronicles the migratory movements in which we may find the first drafts of a million ancestral sagas. As you board the vessel, remember what the connoisseur of opium says elsewhere in the book: let not a wisp escape.

SAURABH SINGH



Crossing the Divide

Insightful forays into the hearts and minds of a range of Pakistanis



A JOURNEY INTERRUPTED: BEING INDIAN IN PAKISTAN

by FARZANA VERSEY

HarperCollins

Price: Rs 295; Pages: 279

■ By Dilip Bobb

Author and conflict resolution expert Terrel Northrup's seminal Theory of Intractable Conflicts holds that conflicts are considered intractable when there is 1) poor or non-existent communication between parties, 2) extreme rigidity in positions, 3) a high level of hostility and attempts by at least one party to harm the other, and 4) conflict that is accepted as inevitable and glorified. The Indo-Pakistan equation qualifies on all those parameters. Despite the Confidence Building Measures (CBMs), there is little difference in attitudes or actions. Both remain locked in self-perpetuating hostility and distorted perceptions.

Has that changed in an environment where economic issues are taking precedence and Pakistan embraces democracy? Farzana Versey is a columnist who made frequent trips to Pakistan, meeting a cross section of Pakistani society. She wears a unique identity: an Indian, a woman travelling alone and a Muslim. This is not a trav-

elogue but an attempt to penetrate the Pakistan psyche, a crusade that takes her to cocktail parties in the mansions of the rich, rundown guest houses in the grubby alleys of urban cities and the mosques where Mullahs spew their sermons of hate.

It's a troubling journey into a complex society trapped between western liberalism and radical Islam, where distortions about India and Indian Muslims dominate most conversations. Despite its imperfections—a jerky, disjointed narrative and long passages of recorded history—this is an interesting book, made so by the searching questions she asks her protagonists and gets asked in return. It reads like a heated debate, on theology, diplomacy, perceptions, the Muslim identity and radicalism, democracy and dictatorship and cultural cross currents. Versey terms the CBMs as "designer peace" and concludes that real peace will never come: being anti-Indian is a crucial component of the Pakistan identity despite their obsession with Bollywood films and Indian television soaps. She writes with anguish and pessimism, a journey into hearts of darkness with no light at the end of that distorted prism, mainly because as she astutely observes, "every few years Pakistan writes a new fiction" to keep the embers alive.